something special about the interaction between a conscious mind and a quantum system. Could the collapse of the wave function be caused by the conscious perception of certain aspects of physical objects?

According to the textbook view, wave functions collapse when they are measured, but what precisely constitutes "measurement" is left a little vague. The Copenhagen interpretation posits a distinction between quantum and classical realms, and treats measurement as an interaction between a classical observer and a quantum system. Where we should draw the line is hard to specify. If we have a Geiger counter observing emission from a radioactive source, for example, it would be natural to treat the counter as part of the classical world. But we don't have to; even in Copenhagen, we could imagine treating Geiger counters as quantum systems that obey the Schrödinger equation. It's only when the outcome of a measurement is perceived by a human being that (in this way of thinking) the wave function absolutely has to collapse, because no human being has ever reported being in a superposition of different measurement outcomes. So the last possible place we can draw the cut is between "observers who can testify as to whether they are in a superposition" and "everything else." Since the perception of not being in a superposition is part of our consciousness, it's not crazy to ask whether it's actually consciousness that causes the collapse.

This idea was put forward as early as 1939, by Fritz London and Edmond Bauer, and later gained favor with Eugene Wigner, who won the Nobel Prize for his work on symmetries. In Wigner's words:

> All that quantum mechanics purports to provide are probability connections between subsequent impressions (also called "apperceptions") of the consciousness, and even though the dividing line between the observer, whose consciousness is being affected, and the observed physical object can be shifted towards the one or the other to a considerable degree, it cannot be eliminated. It may be premature to believe that the present philosophy of quantum mechanics will remain a permanent feature of future physical theories; it will remain remarkable, in whatever way our future concepts may develop, that the very study of the external world led to the conclusion that the content of the consciousness is an ultimate reality.

Wigner himself later changed his mind about the role of consciousness in quantum theory, but others have taken up the torch. It's not generally a view you will hear spoken of approvingly at physics conferences, but there are some scientists out there who continue to take it seriously.